

27 Miles in the Snow; Honoring the Courage of December Escapes and Visualizing Freedom's Routes Into and Out of Philadelphia

Author: 1838 Black Metropolis

Date: December 24, 2024

During winter, we reflect on enslaved individuals planning December escapes. The anxiety must have been profound, especially for families with children worried about surviving freezing conditions.

Many Freedom Seekers departed in December because New Year's Day was when enslavers settled debts, potentially splitting families apart. Whole families often escaped together to stay united.

The Hawkins Family Escapes with Six Children in Winter

William Still's *Underground Railroad* documents the Hawkins family's arrival at John Hunn's Delaware home in December 1845. The group consisted of "a man, his wife, with their six children," four additional men, and conductor Samuel Burris. They had "walked 27 miles through a snowstorm" and "most of them were badly frost-bitten" upon arrival. One man's boot was frozen to his feet.

Though discovered and jailed, Anti-Slavery Society member Thomas Garrett secured their release. They subsequently settled in Byberry, Pennsylvania.

New! UGRR Routes are Now on Our Map

Philadelphia emerges as crucial to Underground Railroad operations. Wilber Siebert's historical map demonstrates that "Philly is the destination" of Eastern route lines. The organization combined Siebert's routes with oral histories from historian Shamele Jordan, William Still's documentation, and Harriet Tubman Byway information, integrating this data into their interactive map.

Red routes indicate heightened danger until arrival in Philadelphia; green routes show increased safety northward. Estimates suggest 1,000-1,700 Freedom Seekers passed through Philadelphia annually, making Underground Railroad stations exceptionally busy.

The Importance of Macedonia AME and Camden, NJ

Founded in 1832, Macedonia AME Church in Camden, New Jersey served as sanctuary and waypoint for northbound travelers. Pastor Thomas Clement Oliver was an important Underground Railroad conductor. Macedonia mysteriously burned in 1839 but was rebuilt on the same location.

The church itself concealed Underground Railroad travelers. When slave catchers transported a captured man past the church toward the river, he cried "Kidnappers!" The congregation responded powerfully, surrounding the wagon and pulling the man free. Churchgoer Hannah Bowen cut the ropes, and slave catchers fled "for their own personal safety."

Putting it Together: The Hawkins' Route Visualized

The Hawkins family traveled from Camden to New Castle, Delaware along major UGRR routes. They continued to Wilmington, then Byberry, where the wealthy Purvis family at Harmony Hall provided refuge. Robert Purvis reported that 9,000 Freedom Seekers came through Harmony Hall before the Civil War.

Macedonia AME Still Stands!

Macedonia AME Church remains standing nearly 200 years later in the same location, visible from the river. Church historian Ramona Chainey notes that Macedonia's oral history contains numerous Underground Railroad stories. The congregation demonstrated fierce commitment to justice and civil rights throughout its history.

Conclusion

This holiday season, read Underground Railroad stories aloud and use the interactive map to visualize travelers' journeys. Consider the remarkable courage of thousands who eventually "made it over" to freedom.

Images

- Underground Railroad (1893) by Charles T. Webber from Cincinnati Art Museum — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_79730b484f4149b681bfcd798cbeab6b~mv2.jpg

- Samuel D. Burris, Underground Railroad Conductor, from William Still's Underground Railroad — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_7cad7b695ee04069995c1cd85efd3432~mv2.png
- William Still's Underground Railroad, Page 715 excerpt — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_cc27b67c30754d23b9ed1f297791001a~mv2.png
- Underground Routes by Wilber Siebert (first image) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_25347837f44d4a7288b70aa2132763bf~mv2.jpg
- Underground Routes by Wilber Siebert (detail) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_45a4f0a93b22410f85fea0ebdc36c6e2~mv2.jpg
- Hawkins family route map 1 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_1238b2c6508548c79bf51434f8babfef~mv2.png
- Hawkins family route map 2 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_3387bfbd375241adb8095c4731d4ae67~mv2.png
- Philadelphia traffic calculation — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_9731f8d9f5714f5cb680d56b08a1636e~mv2.png
- Macedonia AME junction routes — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_085287d99e1b4bf9bb649f730b219777~mv2.png
- Macedonia AME Church, Camden, NJ — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_b3a48f035f1443ccadef0935fdaebd91~mv2.jpeg

WORDCOUNT: 1,087